MANDARIN ZEST
中文皮

CHARACTER CHALLENGE

172
strokes, as it is usually counted

12
building blocks you can learn first

9
steps from top to bottom



How to write huáng

The most complicated "character" you'll ever meet, broken into simple pieces you already know.

BEFORE YOU START

Meet huáng

huáng

> If biáng is the boss level of Chinese noodles, huáng is the final boss. It is usually said to have **172 strokes**, about three times as many as biáng.



You won't find huáng in standard dictionaries, and you can't type it on your phone. Its origin is unknown, and many people see it as a piece of art rather than a real character: its layout looks a lot like a Taoist talisman, and one popular reading calls it "a depiction of heaven".

That makes it the perfect exercise. Huáng uses the same building blocks and the same stroke order rules as everyday characters. If you can write 雨 田 土 回 云 飛 鳳 龍 風 鹿 山, you can write huáng.

172
strokes, as usually counted

~57
strokes in biáng, for comparison

12
familiar building blocks

THE IDEA OF THIS GUIDE

Don't count strokes. Count blocks. Huáng is just 12 familiar pieces arranged in rows, and you'll build it one row at a time.

STEP 1 · KNOW YOUR PIECES

The 12 building blocks

部件 bùjiàn

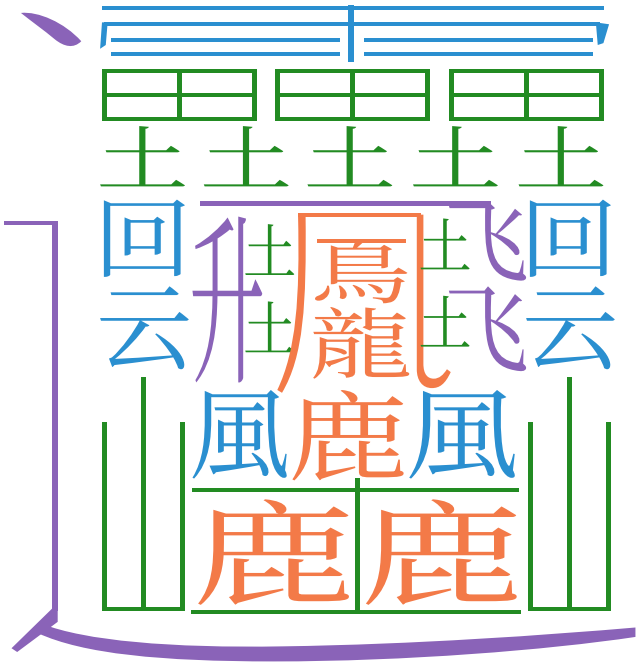
Every colour below is a family of meaning. Read huáng like a picture: rain and clouds above, fields and mountains below, creatures in the middle, and movement all around.

Sky & weather
雨 回 云 風
Rain, swirling clouds and wind fill the top and sides.

Land
田 土 山
Fields, earth and mountains hold everything up.

Creatures
鳳 龍 鹿
The phoenix, the dragon and three deer live in the middle.

Movement
飛 辶
Flying around the phoenix, and walking around it all.



雨	rain yǔ	×1	8 strokes
田	field tián	×3	5 strokes
土	earth (one big 土 holds the two 鹿) tǔ	×10	3 strokes
回	to turn, return huí	×2	6 strokes
云	cloud yún	×2	4 strokes
鳳	phoenix, its frame stretched around 龍 fèng	×1	14 strokes
龍	dragon lóng	×1	16 strokes
飛	to fly, split around 鳳 fēi	×1	9 strokes
風	wind fēng	×2	9 strokes
鹿	deer lù	×3	11 strokes
山	mountain shān	×2	3 strokes
辶	walking chuò	×1	3 strokes

Add up the blocks **172 strokes**

STEP 2 · PUT IT TOGETHER

Build it in 9 steps

写
xiě

Follow the rules from Lesson 4 of our characters guide: **top to bottom**, **left to right**, and the walking radical 辶 **last**, just like in 这. The new piece in each step is in orange; grey shows what's still to come.

1



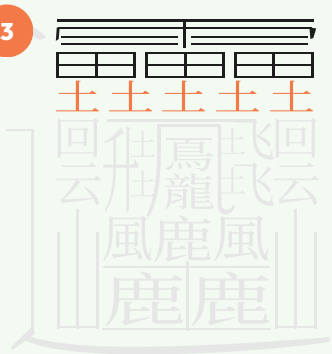
雨 Rain on top

2



田 ×3 Three fields

3



土 ×5 Five earths

4



回 云 Left cloud

5



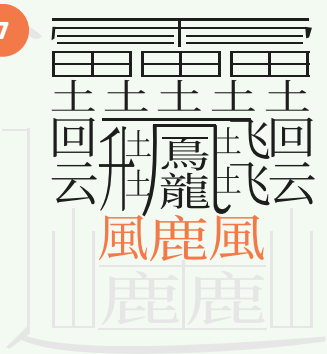
飛 鳳 龍 土 The centre

6



回 云 Right cloud

7



風 鹿 風 Wind and deer

8



山 土 鹿 鹿 山 Mountains, earth and deer

9

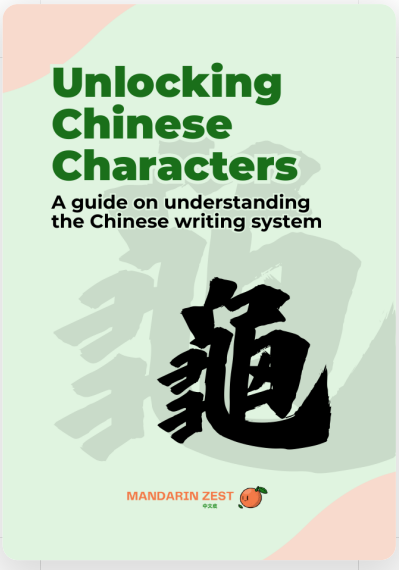


辶 Walk, last

KEEP GOING

You just wrote 172 strokes!

Huáng is the extreme case, but every character works the same way: familiar blocks, put together with a few simple rules.



OUR GUIDE

Unlocking Chinese Characters

Learn where characters come from, the six ways they are built, radicals, stroke order and how to develop your own handwriting.

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加油!